

Cetaceans

Order Cetacea

Gray whale

Eschrichtius robustus

- ↔ 43–49 ft (13–15 m)
- 📍 North Pacific
- ⊗ Locally common

This coastal Pacific species is one of the larger filter-feeding whales, albeit one with an unusual foraging technique. As well as sifting small planktonic animals from open water, it dives to the shallow seabed and scoops up mouthfuls of mud; it then strains the mud for animals such as worms, starfish, and shrimp. In summer, it migrates north along the coast to feed in the Arctic seas north of Alaska, returning south in winter to breed in the warm waters off Mexico.



Southern right whale

Eubalaena australis

- ↔ Up to 59 ft (18 m)
- 📍 Southern Ocean
- ⊗ Common

One of two species of right whale, this mammal lives in the Southern Ocean around Antarctica, but avoids the very coldest waters; the other species lives in the Arctic. It feeds on small planktonic animals by straining food-rich water through the bristlelike baleen that lines its mouth in place of teeth. Unusually, up to eight males may mate with each female—there is no rivalry between the males.

Amazon river dolphin

Inia geoffrensis

- ↔ 7–9 ft (2–2.7 m)
- 📍 South America (Amazon and Orinoco basins)
- ⊗ Locally common

One of five river dolphin species, this pink or gray mammal has a long, slim snout and a flexible neck. It uses echolocation to find its way in muddy rivers and seasonal floodwaters, probing submerged vegetation for freshwater crabs, fish, and turtles. It seizes prey with peg-like teeth at the front of its jaws and crushes it with bigger cheek teeth.

Bowhead whale

Balaena mysticetus

- ↔ 46–59 ft (14–18 m)
- 📍 Arctic and subarctic waters
- ⊗ Common

This large filter-feeding whale gets its name from its high-arched upper jaw—part of a massive head that accounts for 40 percent of the animal's length. It lives near the edge of the Arctic pack ice, where it feeds by swimming with its mouth open to force water in at the front and out through the mesh of baleen at each side. This traps swarming animals, such as shrimplike copepods, which it then swallows.

Pantropical spotted dolphin

Stenella attenuata

- ↔ 5–9 ft (1.5–2.7 m)
- 📍 Temperate and tropical waters worldwide
- ⊗ Common

Widespread in all warm oceans, this slender dolphin swims in large schools, often associating with schools of tuna to hunt smaller fish. Once threatened by industrial tuna fishing—thousands were trapped and drowned in tuna nets—“dolphin friendly” techniques have allowed it to recover.

Humpback whale

Megaptera novaeangliae

- ↔ 43–46 ft (13–14 m)
- 📍 Worldwide (except Mediterranean, Baltic, Red Sea, Arabian Gulf)
- ⊗ Common

The humpback whale has a knobby head and unusually long pectoral flippers. It feeds by using its expandable, pleated throat to engulf large quantities of water, which it then strains for small prey. Groups also herd fish to the surface by blowing bubbles around them, and lunge upward through the water to swallow them. Vocal and sociable, it communicates using various sounds, including “whale songs” performed by the males.



Short-beaked common dolphin

Delphinus delphis

- ↔ 8–9 ft (2.4–2.7 m)
- 📍 Temperate and tropical waters worldwide
- ⊗ Common

A typical fast-swimming, sociable dolphin, this species has a dark back and a distinctive wavelike pattern of yellow on each flank, overlapping with a similar pattern in gray nearer the tail. It hunts offshore in deep waters, pursuing schooling fish and squid in large schools. The dolphins stay in contact with a variety of clicking, squeaking, and croaking calls that are loud enough to be heard from nearby boats.

Short-finned pilot whale

Globicephala macrorhynchus

- ↔ 16–23 ft (5–7 m)
- 📍 Temperate and tropical waters worldwide
- ⊗ Not known

This stocky relative of the dolphins has a very short snout topped with a bulbous forehead. It is black or dark gray all over, aside from an anchor-shaped pale patch on its throat. It feeds mainly on deep-water squid, diving to depths of 1,600 ft (500 m) to pursue them through the oceanic twilight zone. Males weigh almost twice as much as females, and scars on their bodies may be evidence of fights between rivals.

Sperm whale

Physeter macrocephalus

- ↔ 36–65 ft (11–20 m)
- 📍 Deep waters worldwide
- ⊗ Vulnerable

The largest of the toothed whales, this oceanic giant has an enormous, boxy head and a long, narrow lower jaw armed with 20–26 pairs of large, conical teeth. It uses them to catch squid, octopus, and fish, diving to depths of well below 3,300 ft (1,000 m), sometimes staying submerged for almost an hour. It regularly targets deep-water giant squid—many sperm whales bear big circular scars inflicted by the giant squid's toothed suckers.

Other species

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